

DIVERSITY, EQUITY, AND INCLUSION STATEMENT

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As an international student and a person of color in biostatistics, I do not think of diversity and inclusion as abstract ideas. They are part of my daily experience. I still remember sitting in graduate seminars in the United States, often one of very few international students or students of color in the room. I would sometimes weigh whether a question I wanted to ask would be heard as curiosity, or as evidence that I did not belong. That hesitation is not unique to me. It is the quiet tax that underrepresentation places on people who are already working twice as hard to feel at home in a discipline. I carry the memory of it into every classroom I teach. I do not carry it as a grievance, but as information. It tells me exactly where students lose confidence. It also tells me exactly where a small, deliberate act by a teacher can change the direction of a student's relationship with the field. Statistics and biostatistics, like many quantitative fields, still struggle with representation. I am committed to doing my part to build a discipline in which students and scholars from all backgrounds feel that they belong, and feel that their perspectives genuinely improve the science.

My approach to equity rests on a simple idea: inclusion is not a value you announce. It is a set of practices you build into the ordinary mechanics of a course. The barriers students face are rarely dramatic. They are the student who has the right answer but will not risk saying it aloud. They are the student who understands the concept but freezes on the one assessment format the course happens to use. They are the first-generation student who assumes office hours are for other people. Because these barriers are ordinary, the remedies must be ordinary and structural too. They must help every student in the room, not only the ones who know to ask. In my teaching I use anonymous in-class polling so that students who are hesitant to speak publicly can still contribute their reasoning and see that it was correct. That is often the moment a quiet student begins to believe they belong. I also use collaborative review tools so that students with different learning styles have more than one route into the material. I deliberately offer assessments in several formats, including problem sets, coding labs, short written reflections, and collaborative projects. I do this not to lower expectations, but to make sure a student's grade reflects their statistical understanding rather than their fluency with a single way of showing it. I design groups with intention, putting together teams that bring students from different backgrounds together, because I have seen repeatedly how much students learn from peers whose path to the same problem was different from their own. My evaluations consistently show that students feel respected, encouraged, and supported. I take that as evidence that inclusivity and rigor are not in tension: students reason more ambitiously when they are confident their voice will be taken seriously.

I pay special attention to first-generation and international students, because I have been both. Students who are the first in their families to attend university are often less likely to seek help. It is not because they need it less. It is because they are not certain it is available to them, and a single discouraging interaction can confirm a fear they already carried. I therefore treat access as something I must actively extend, not passively offer. I state explicitly and repeatedly that office hours are for everyone. I normalize asking questions by modeling uncertainty in my own reasoning at the board. I also reach out to students who are struggling before they reach out to me, since the students who most need support are often the least likely to request it. One lesson I have learned, through both being mentored and mentoring others, is that good support requires listening before advising. Every student's barriers are different. Effective mentorship means understanding a specific person's situation, not assuming their challenges fit a familiar pattern. I bring that discipline of listening to every advising relationship I take on.

This commitment extends beyond my own classroom into the institutional work of building communities where students feel they belong. At the University of Nebraska Medical Center, I served as Treasurer of the College of Public Health Student Association. In that role, I managed the association's budget and helped organize events that brought together graduate students from diverse backgrounds across the college. That role gave me a close, practical view of how community-building at the graduate level shapes whether students feel they have a place in a program. It also deepened my conviction that belonging is produced by sustained institutional effort, not by good intentions alone. I have also mentored students from underrepresented groups directly, helping them navigate the unwritten expectations of graduate study and access research and professional opportunities that are easy to miss without someone pointing the way. As a faculty member, I intend to make this work explicit rather than incidental: through structured mentoring, transparent expectations, and active recruitment of students who do not yet see themselves in quantitative research.

My research itself has an equity dimension that I see as central rather than incidental. The health problems I study, namely environmental chemical exposures and their effects on disease outcomes, do not fall equally across communities. Rural communities, agricultural workers, and lower-income populations often bear a disproportionate share of environmental health burdens. Yet they are often underrepresented in the data and underserved by the methods used to analyze it. When a statistical model is too coarse or too unstable to detect a localized health effect, the communities that disappear first are the ones with the least power to demand that the analysis be done better. Developing scalable methods that can reliably detect these effects, and applying them to surveillance data that captures how exposure is

distributed across communities, is part of how my methodological work contributes to environmental justice in concrete terms. Good statistics in service of the communities that bear the heaviest burdens is not a secondary concern in my research; it is one of the reasons I do it.

I believe a discipline is strongest when it draws on the widest range of perspectives. I also believe that the institutions producing the next generation of statisticians have a responsibility to widen, not narrow, who gets to do this work. I am committed to advancing this in four ways: through inclusive classrooms that build equity into their ordinary structure; through mentorship that listens before it advises; through institutional service that makes belonging a sustained practice; and through research that keeps the most burdened communities visible in the data. I look forward to contributing to an academic environment that is at once intellectually rigorous and genuinely inclusive, in the conviction that these two commitments do not compete; they reinforce each other.